

Your precision clean bulk protocol

You need to start at 2,700 calories daily with 155g protein, 375g carbs, and 60g fat, targeting 0.25-0.35 kg weekly weight gain. (Fitbod) This conservative surplus maximizes muscle growth while

minimizing fat accumulation for someone at your training level (1 year consistent). Over 2-3 months, expect to gain 1.5-2 kg of actual muscle tissue alongside 2-2.5 kg of fat—realistic numbers that keep you lean while building meaningful strength. The week-by-week adjustment system below provides exact decision rules for every scenario you'll encounter, starting today, Friday October 10th, 2025.

This protocol matters because as an intermediate lifter at 10-11% body fat, you're in the optimal position to build muscle efficiently. However, your slower muscle accrual rate compared to beginners means excessive calories become fat storage rather than muscle tissue. Research confirms trained lifters gaining weight faster than 0.5% weekly don't build more muscle—they just accumulate more fat.

(Bodyrecomposition +2) The meticulous tracking system outlined here ensures you stay in the sweet spot where every calorie works toward your goals.

Your starting numbers: calculated for 71 kg at 2,500 kcal maintenance

Starting your bulk requires precision based on your verified maintenance calories. At 71 kg bodyweight with a confirmed 2,400-2,500 kcal maintenance over six days of stable weight, you're positioned to begin with **2,700 kcal daily**—a conservative 200 kcal surplus that research shows optimizes muscle-to-fat ratios for intermediate lifters. (Fitbod) This modest 8% increase above maintenance represents the Goldilocks zone: enough to fuel muscle growth, not so much that excess energy converts predominantly to fat storage.

Your macronutrient breakdown reflects evidence-based optimization for someone training six days weekly with high activity levels. **Protein at 155g daily (2.18g/kg bodyweight)** sits at the upper end of the research-supported range where muscle protein synthesis maximizes, according to Morton's 2018 meta-analysis showing no additional benefit beyond 2.2g/kg. This provides 620 calories or 23% of your

total intake, distributed across 4-5 meals at 30-40g per meal to maintain elevated muscle protein synthesis throughout the day.

Carbohydrates at 375g daily (5.3g/kg bodyweight) fuel your intense training schedule and support optimal recovery. Renaissance Periodization's analysis demonstrates high-carb approaches produce superior muscle gains with less fat accumulation due to better energy partitioning—excess carbohydrates are preferentially oxidized for energy rather than stored as fat, unlike dietary fat. (RP Strength) With your athletic work throughout the day plus six training sessions weekly, you need this carbohydrate volume to maintain glycogen stores and training capacity. This delivers 1,500 calories representing 56% of total intake.

Fat at 60g daily (0.85g/kg bodyweight) provides 540 calories or 20% of intake, meeting hormonal production requirements while leaving room for muscle-building carbohydrates. Research confirms 0.3g/lb (0.66g/kg) as the minimum for hormone health, so your 60g target provides comfortable margin above this threshold. Focus on omega-3 rich sources like fatty fish, monounsaturated fats from olive oil and avocados, and minimize saturated fat to optimize inflammation control and cardiovascular health during your bulk.

This starting point targets **0.25-0.35 kg weekly weight gain**, translating to roughly 1-1.4 kg monthly. This rate sits firmly in the intermediate lifter sweet spot identified across multiple research models—Alan Aragon's 0.5-1% bodyweight monthly, Lyle McDonald's approximately 0.5 kg muscle monthly with 1:1 muscle-to-fat ratio, and Eric Helms' recommendation of 0.5-1% monthly for one-year trained individuals. (MacroFactor) (revivestronger) The slower rate maximizes your muscle-to-fat gain ratio, with research by Garthe showing 0.16% weekly bodyweight gain produced 85% lean mass versus just 65% lean mass at faster rates. (macrofactorapp) (MacroFactor)

What 2-3 months will actually deliver

Setting realistic expectations prevents frustration and helps you stay the course. Over the next two months, expect to gain **1.2-1.6 kg of actual muscle tissue** alongside **1.5-2 kg of fat**, for total scale weight

increase of 2.7-3.6 kg. Extending to three months yields **1.8-2.4 kg muscle** with **2-3 kg fat**, totaling 3.8-5.4 kg gained. Your body fat percentage climbs from 10-11% to approximately 12-13% after two months, or 12-14% after three months—you'll maintain visible abdominal definition and stay well within the range where insulin sensitivity and anabolic response remain optimal.

These projections reflect converging evidence from multiple research models. Lyle McDonald's intermediate model predicts 0.45-0.5 kg muscle monthly, Alan Aragon's framework suggests 0.35-0.71 kg monthly at 0.5-1% bodyweight, and recent Stronger By Science data confirms intermediates gain approximately 0.1-0.2% muscle size increase per training day. (revivestronger) Your one year of consistent training places you past the "newbie gains" window but with significant room remaining before approaching genetic limits—at 185cm height with current lean mass around 64 kg, Casey Butt and Menno Henselmans models estimate your natural potential near 78-82 kg lean mass, leaving 14-18 kg of muscle-building potential over 3-5 years.

The muscle-to-fat ratio deserves emphasis because it separates clean bulks from sloppy weight gain. At optimal gain rates, intermediate lifters achieve **1:1 to 2:1 fat-to-muscle ratios**—meaning for every kilogram of muscle gained, you add one to two kilograms of fat. This compares favorably to aggressive bulks producing 3:1 or worse ratios where fat accumulation dominates. (Outlift) Helms' 2023 study demonstrated faster weight gain doesn't accelerate muscle growth in trained individuals (correlation $R^2 = 0-0.24$) but strongly predicts fat accumulation ($R^2 = 0.49$). (macrofactorapp) (MacroFactor) Translation: eating more doesn't force-feed muscle growth beyond your physiological capacity.

Strength progression provides the clearest signal your bulk is working. Expect **2-5% increases on major lifts in month one**, tapering to **2-4% in month two** and **1-3% in month three** as neural adaptations plateau and actual tissue building becomes the primary driver. For your current bodyweight bench press (71 kg), this means adding 1.5-3.5 kg in month one. Your 10 pull-ups might climb to 12-13 reps, while dips jump from 15+ to potentially 18-20 reps. Progressive overload remains non-negotiable—if you're gaining weight without gaining strength, something needs adjustment in either calorie intake, protein consumption, or training program.

Month-by-month, your scale weight follows a predictable pattern accounting for physiological realities.

Month one shows 1.5-2 kg total gain, but don't panic—this includes 0.5-1 kg of glycogen and water from increased carbohydrate and food volume. Actual tissue gain is 0.4-0.7 kg muscle plus 0.5-0.9 kg fat.

Month two adds 0.9-1.2 kg, now predominantly real tissue with minimal water weight contribution.

Month three contributes another 0.9-1.2 kg following the same pattern. This creates the total projections above while explaining why Week 1's dramatic weight jump doesn't represent actual body composition change.

The week-by-week adjustment system: your decision-making protocol

This detailed protocol eliminates guesswork by providing exact rules for every situation. Starting today, Friday October 10th, you'll follow a systematic approach to daily weighing, weekly averaging, trend analysis, and calorie adjustments that ensures your bulk stays on track.

Daily weighing ritual establishes your data foundation. Every morning immediately after waking and using the bathroom, before consuming any food or water, step on the scale naked or in consistent minimal clothing. Same scale, same location, same conditions. This consistency controls for variables that can swing bodyweight 0.5-1.4 kg daily—gut content from digestive transit, water retention from sodium intake, glycogen storage fluctuations, and training-induced inflammation. [Medical News Today](#) Log the number immediately in your tracking app or spreadsheet. Note any anomalies like poor sleep, high sodium meals the previous day, alcohol consumption, travel, or illness that might explain unusual readings.

Weekly averaging reveals true trends beneath daily noise. Each week from Friday to Thursday, sum your seven daily weights and divide by seven to get your weekly average. Week 1 runs October 10-16, 2025. Week 2 covers October 17-23. Continue this pattern indefinitely. Weekly averages smooth out the random fluctuations that would otherwise trigger unnecessary calorie adjustments. For example, if your Week 1 daily weights are 71.0, 71.3, 71.6, 71.2, 71.4, 71.1, and 71.5 kg, your Week 1 average equals $498.1 \div 7 = \mathbf{71.16 \text{ kg}}$.

Week 1 data gets completely ignored for decision-making purposes—this is crucial. You'll likely see 1-3 kg weight increase in Week 1, but this represents glycogen replenishment and water retention from increased food volume and carbohydrate intake, not fat or muscle tissue. Each gram of glycogen binds 3-4 grams of water, and increasing from 2,500 to 2,700 calories with higher carb intake triggers predictable water retention. (PureGym) Panicking and cutting calories based on Week 1's spike sabotages your bulk before it begins. Record the data, observe the pattern, but take zero action.

Week 2 provides your first data point but still no action. Calculate Week 2 average the same way. The change from Week 1 to Week 2 will be much smaller, possibly even showing slight decrease as initial water retention stabilizes. This is normal. You're still observing, establishing baseline patterns, not making decisions. Continue eating 2,700 calories daily with your prescribed macros.

Week 3 delivers your first meaningful measurement. Calculate Week 3 average and compare it to Week 2 average. This represents your first real weight change data after the initial water retention settles. If Week 2 averaged 71.8 kg and Week 3 averages 72.1 kg, you gained 0.3 kg that week. Still don't adjust calories yet—one data point doesn't establish a trend. Week-to-week fluctuations of ± 0.3 -0.5 kg remain common even after initial water retention stabilizes.

Week 4 marks your first assessment and potential adjustment. Calculate Week 4 average, then compute your average weekly gain from Weeks 2-4. This three-week span provides sufficient data to identify actual trends versus random variation. Your target is **0.25-0.35 kg weekly**. Calculate the average: if Week 2 was 71.8 kg, Week 3 was 72.1 kg, and Week 4 is 72.4 kg, your changes are +0.3 kg and +0.3 kg, averaging 0.3 kg weekly—right in your target range.

Decision rules for Week 4 assessment follow clear thresholds. If your average weekly gain is 0.25-0.35 kg, **make no changes**—you're on target. If average weekly gain is **below 0.25 kg**, you're gaining too slowly and should **add 150 kcal daily**, primarily from carbohydrates (approximately 35g carbs, or 30g carbs plus 5g fat). If average weekly gain **exceeds 0.4 kg**, verify it's not water retention from increased training volume, new supplements like creatine, or high sodium intake. If confirmed as real trend over three weeks, **subtract 100-150 kcal daily** from carbs and fats while maintaining protein.

Ongoing adjustments every 2-3 weeks maintain your trajectory. After Week 4's assessment and any adjustment made, monitor for two more weeks before the next decision point. This allows changes time to affect your weight trend—your body doesn't respond instantly to calorie modifications. Continue daily weighing, weekly averaging, and comparing week-to-week changes. Every 2-3 weeks thereafter, assess whether you're maintaining 0.25-0.35 kg weekly gain and adjust by ± 100 -150 kcal as needed.

Distinguishing water retention from real weight gain prevents bad decisions. Water retention shows these characteristics: sudden spike of more than 1 kg in 24-48 hours, preceded by identifiable trigger (high sodium meal, new supplement, increased training volume, poor sleep, alcohol), weight drops back within 3-4 days, no change in mirror appearance, and measurements like waist circumference unchanged. PureGym Real weight gain demonstrates: consistent upward trend over 2+ weeks, measurements increasing, visual changes in mirror, clothes fitting differently, and strength consistently progressing. When uncertain, err toward patience—wait another week before adjusting.

Specific calorie adjustment calculations use this formula: Take your target weekly gain (0.3 kg as midpoint), subtract actual weekly gain, then multiply by 7,700 kcal (calories per kg of bodyweight) divided by 7 days. Each 0.1 kg weekly difference requires approximately **100 kcal daily adjustment**. If you're gaining 0.15 kg weekly versus 0.3 kg target, you're 0.15 kg slow, requiring $0.15 \times 7,700 \div 7 = 165$ **kcal addition**. Round to 150-200 kcal for practical purposes.

The two-week rolling average provides additional stability for experienced lifters with slower target rates. Calculate the average of Week 3 and Week 4's weekly averages, then compare to the average of Week 5 and Week 6's weekly averages. This smooths noise even further. If Week 3 averaged 72.1 kg and Week 4 averaged 72.4 kg, their average is 72.25 kg. If Week 5 averages 72.6 kg and Week 6 averages 72.9 kg, their average is 72.75 kg—a 0.5 kg gain over two weeks, or 0.25 kg weekly, slightly below target.

Special situations require adjusted interpretation. Starting creatine supplementation adds 1-2 kg water weight in the first week—MDPI note this in your log and expect it, making no calorie adjustments until

water retention stabilizes after 2-3 weeks. [PureGym](#) Significantly increased training volume triggers temporary inflammation and water retention of 0.5-1 kg that resolves within 5-7 days. High sodium meals can cause overnight 0.5-1 kg spikes that disappear within 48 hours. [Medical News Today](#) Travel, poor sleep, illness, and stress all affect water retention. Log these factors to interpret weight fluctuations correctly.

Monthly measurement days provide body composition verification. Every four weeks on the same day, take comprehensive measurements: neck, shoulders across deltoids, chest at nipple line, waist at narrowest point (typically just above navel), hips at widest point, arms flexed, and thighs at midpoint. Also take progress photos in consistent lighting wearing the same minimal clothing—front relaxed, front flexed, side relaxed, side flexed, and back poses. Your goal is seeing chest and shoulder measurements increase faster than waist measurement. If waist grows 2 cm while chest grows 1 cm over a month, you're accumulating excess fat and need to slow your gain rate.

Best practices for maximizing muscle while minimizing fat

Beyond calories and tracking, specific strategies optimize body composition during your surplus. These evidence-based practices separate efficient muscle building from sloppy bulking.

Training optimization drives muscle growth as much as nutrition. Your current six-day split provides excellent frequency, but volume and progressive overload determine results. Research confirms **10-20 sets per muscle group weekly** as the effective range for hypertrophy, with most people responding best to 12-16 sets. [Men's Health](#) Each muscle should be trained **at least twice weekly** for optimal protein synthesis frequency. [PubMed](#) [Mennohenselmans](#) Your split hits most muscles 2-3 times weekly, which aligns perfectly with evidence. Progressive overload—adding weight, reps, or sets over time—remains non-negotiable. If strength stalls despite calorie surplus and adequate protein, investigate recovery, sleep, or programming rather than immediately adding more calories.

Creatine monohydrate is the only supplement with overwhelming evidence for lean mass gains. More than 500 peer-reviewed studies confirm 3-5g daily increases lean mass by approximately 1.1 kg versus training alone, enhances strength and power output, and improves recovery between sets. [Healthline](#) Take

3-5g daily (or 0.03g/kg bodyweight = 2.1g for your 71 kg, though 5g is standard dosing) consistently regardless of timing. Optional loading protocol of 20g daily for 5-7 days, then 3-5g maintenance, saturates muscles faster but produces the same long-term results. (Examine) Creatine is extensively studied for safety with no significant adverse effects even at 30g daily for five years. (BioMed Central)

Protein timing matters minimally when total daily intake is adequate. Multiple systematic reviews including Schoenfeld's meta-analysis confirm that hitting your 155g daily protein target trumps timing considerations. (BioMed Central) The "anabolic window" extends 24-48 hours post-workout, not just 1-2 hours. (PubMed Central +2) That said, distributing protein across 4-5 meals at 30-40g each optimizes muscle protein synthesis throughout the day. The research suggests 0.4-0.6g/kg (28-43g for your 71 kg) per meal maximizes acute muscle protein synthesis response. Practical implementation: eat protein-rich meals every 3-5 hours when possible, but don't stress if circumstances occasionally require different spacing.

Cardiovascular exercise maintains health without impeding gains when dosed appropriately. Aim for **2-3 low-intensity sessions weekly totaling 60-90 minutes**, such as 20-30 minute walks or bike rides. This improves recovery through enhanced blood flow and nutrient delivery while maintaining cardiovascular health for your future cutting phase. Schedule cardio 8+ hours away from resistance training or on rest days to prevent interference effects. Avoid excessive cardio volume exceeding 150 minutes weekly or high-intensity interval training more than once weekly, as research shows excessive concurrent training impairs muscle growth through competing adaptations and recovery demands.

Food quality influences body composition beyond calories. While total calorie and protein intake drive results, emphasizing whole foods over processed options provides advantages. Protein and carbohydrates have higher thermic effects (20-30% and 10-15% respectively) compared to fats (0-3%), meaning you burn more calories digesting them. (Outlift) Whole foods typically provide superior micronutrient density, supporting recovery and health. Fiber from whole food carb sources (rice, oats, potatoes, fruits, vegetables) enhances satiety and digestive health. (Healthline) This doesn't mean zero processed food—flexible dieting allows treats while hitting targets—but a foundation of whole foods optimizes results.

Sleep is non-negotiable for muscle growth. Consistently achieving **7-9 hours nightly** is as important as training and nutrition. Growth hormone release peaks during deep sleep, testosterone production requires adequate sleep, and sleep deprivation impairs recovery while increasing cortisol. Research shows even partial sleep restriction significantly blunts muscle protein synthesis and shifts weight gain toward fat rather than muscle. If choosing between an extra training session or an extra hour of sleep, choose sleep —your body builds muscle during recovery, not in the gym.

Alcohol consumption directly impairs muscle growth through multiple mechanisms: decreased muscle protein synthesis for up to 24 hours post-consumption, impaired recovery, reduced sleep quality, and empty calories that don't support training. Limit alcohol to 1-2 drinks maximum on occasional social occasions, and avoid it entirely within 24 hours of important training sessions. Heavy drinking (4+ drinks) can reduce muscle protein synthesis by 30-40% even when protein intake is adequate.

Warning signs you're bulking too fast

Recognizing when your bulk has shifted from lean mass gain to excessive fat accumulation enables timely corrections before you drift too far from optimal body composition.

Rate-based red flags are the clearest indicators. If you're consistently gaining **more than 0.5 kg weekly after the initial two-week water retention phase**, you're likely accumulating excess fat. For your 71 kg bodyweight, this means 0.7% weekly gain—double the optimal intermediate rate. While beginners occasionally sustain faster rates productively, your one year of training places you past that window. Scale weight should climb steadily but gradually, not rapidly. Similarly, if weekly weigh-ins show large swings—up 1 kg one week, down 0.5 kg the next, up 1.2 kg the following—you're likely dealing with water retention issues from inconsistent sodium intake, variable carb consumption, or inadequate hydration rather than steady tissue accrual.

Visual and measurement changes reveal body composition shifts. Your waist measurement should increase slower than shoulder and chest measurements. If after one month your waist grew 2 cm but shoulders only grew 0.5 cm, fat accumulation is outpacing muscle growth. Complete loss of abdominal

definition, where all six-pack visibility disappears rather than just becoming less defined, suggests body fat has climbed above 15%. [\(Tiger Fitness\)](#) Visible fat accumulation in face (double chin development), lower back (love handles), and hips signals excessive fat gain. [\(Eat This!\)](#) Clothes should fit tighter across chest and shoulders while remaining relatively consistent around the waist—if pants get tight first, slow your gain rate.

Performance indicators sometimes reveal problems. If strength gains stall despite maintaining calorie surplus and adequate protein, several issues might exist: insufficient progressive overload in programming, inadequate recovery between sessions, accumulated fatigue requiring deload, or rarely, simply eating beyond your muscle-building capacity without training stimulus to drive adaptation. Conversely, feeling sluggish during workouts, decreased work capacity, or needing longer rest periods between sets can indicate excessive fat gain is impairing athletic performance.

Health markers occasionally signal problems. While unlikely at modest surplus rates, monitor for increased resting heart rate (more than 5-10 bpm above baseline), elevated blood pressure, sleep quality decline despite adequate duration, and digestive distress from excessive food volume. These suggest either too-aggressive surplus or food quality issues requiring attention.

The 15-20% body fat threshold represents an important ceiling. Research suggests insulin sensitivity and anabolic response may decline above 15% body fat for men, making further bulking progressively less efficient. [\(revivestronger\)](#) At your starting 10-11% body fat, you have comfortable room to bulk to 13-14% (reasonable after 3 months) or even 15% (after 4-5 months) before considering a maintenance phase or mini-cut. Beyond 15%, the muscle-to-fat gain ratio deteriorates and cutting back becomes increasingly necessary.

Conclusion: executing your precise protocol

This protocol succeeds through consistency, not perfection. Starting today at 2,700 calories with 155g protein, 375g carbs, and 60g fat, you'll weigh daily and track weekly averages, making your first adjustment decision at Week 4 based on whether you're hitting 0.25-0.35 kg weekly gain. The numbers

provide clarity—if gaining too slowly, add 150 kcal; if too fast, subtract 100-150 kcal. Monitor for two weeks after each adjustment before reassessing.

Over 2-3 months, realistic expectations are 1.5-2.4 kg actual muscle tissue alongside 2-3 kg fat, keeping you lean around 12-14% body fat while meaningfully stronger. Your bench press climbs 3-6 kg, pull-ups increase by 2-3 reps, and dips jump to 18-20+ reps. These aren't dramatic transformations, but they're real, sustainable gains that compound over years.

The key insight separating successful lean bulks from failed attempts is understanding that you cannot force-feed muscle growth beyond your physiological capacity. Excess calories beyond what your training stimulus can use for muscle building simply become fat storage. [revivestronger](#) By targeting the conservative 0.25-0.35 kg weekly rate, using systematic tracking to adjust course every 2-3 weeks, emphasizing progressive overload in training, and maintaining 7-9 hours sleep nightly, you maximize the muscle-to-fat ratio while staying in the leanness range where muscle building remains efficient.

The meticulous weekly adjustment system eliminates guesswork and prevents the common bulking mistakes of either gaining too fast (accumulating excessive fat) or too slow (leaving gains on the table). Follow the protocol precisely for eight weeks minimum before making any philosophical changes—give the system time to work. Your disciplined tracking mindset aligns perfectly with this evidence-based approach, turning the science into sustainable results.